Cheese: HMTc Standard

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CORRESPONDENCE

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KEYWORDS

heavy metals, food safety, dietary exposure

PUBLICATION HISTORY

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Abstract

The Heavy Metal Tested & Certified standard for cheese of all styles, stated as sold. Cheese carries its own government maximum levels, which reflect the concentration of the cheese matrix; every limit is the strictest such sovereign maximum, with a disclosed read-across where none regulates the exact analyte.

1 | How every number on this standard is set

HMTc Method v2.0 (government-limit default; no dairy reconstitution; disclosed read-across; species/packaging controls)

2 | Master limit table

All values in ppb (µg/kg), as sold basis. A brand meeting every value qualifies for the mark.

ANALYTE	TIER	HMTC LIMIT	BASIS
Lead (Pb)	Tier 1	20	government maximum level
Cadmium (Cd)	Tier 1	500	government maximum level
Total arsenic (tAs)	Tier 2	500	government maximum level
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	Tier 1	≤ tAs	bounded by tAs (reflex speciation)

Mercury, total (tHg)	Tier 1	50	government maximum level
Methylmercury (MeHg)	Tier 1	≤ tHg	bounded by tHg (reflex speciation)
Nickel (Ni)	Tier 2	100	human-grade read-across (European Union)
Tin (Sn)	Tier 2	250,000	human-grade read-across (Singapore)
Aluminium (Al)	Tier 2	500	human-grade read-across (Australia / New Zealand)
Total chromium (Cr)	Tier 2	300	human-grade read-across (China)
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	Tier 2	≤ Cr	bounded by Cr (reflex speciation)

3 | Derivation — where each number comes from

Every cell traces to one named sovereign maximum level (the strictest for the nearest analog), or to an explicit control, not-material, or species-bounded determination. No occurrence statistic selects a certification value.

ANALYTE	HMTC	SOVEREIGN ANALOG / DETERMINATION
Lead (Pb)	20	government maximum level
Cadmium (Cd)	500	government maximum level
Total arsenic (tAs)	500	government maximum level
Inorganic arsenic (iAs)	≤ tAs	iAs carries no product-specific sovereign cell; it is a component of and bounded by its parent total tAs (iAs <= tAs), an enforceable ceiling via reflex speciation rather than an empty cell.
Mercury, total (tHg)	50	government maximum level
Methylmercury (MeHg)	≤ tHg	MeHg carries no product-specific sovereign cell; it is a component of and bounded by its parent total tHg (MeHg <= tHg), an enforceable ceiling via reflex speciation rather than an empty cell.
Nickel (Ni)	100	European Union — human-food analog

Tin (Sn)	250,000	Singapore — human-food analog
Aluminium (Al)	500	Australia / New Zealand — human-food analog
Total chromium (Cr)	300	China — human-food analog
Hexavalent chromium (Cr-VI)	≤ Cr	Cr-VI carries no product-specific sovereign cell; it is a component of and bounded by its parent total Cr (Cr-VI <= Cr), an enforceable ceiling via reflex speciation rather than an empty cell.

4 | Cite this standard

Pendergrass, K. (2026). *Cheese: HMTc standard*. Institute of Contaminant Standards.

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References

[1] Australia / New Zealand — human-food maximum levels
Binds Al. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[2] China — human-food maximum levels
Binds Cr. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[3] European Union — human-food maximum levels
Binds Ni. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

[4] Singapore — human-food maximum levels
Binds Sn. Strictest applicable human-food sovereign maximum for the nearest analog.
MAXIMUM LEVEL

STATUS AND LICENCE

A normative certification standard, editorially reviewed and version-controlled in-house; every value traces to a named sovereign maximum level, disclosed in the derivation. © 2026 Institute of Contaminant Standards / Heavy Metal Certified. All rights reserved.

COMPETING INTERESTS

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DATA AVAILABILITY

The works this reference draws on are listed in full in the references above and on the briefing page at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/dairy-cheese. Primary legal instruments and expert-body assessments are

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This revision 2026-08. The full dated record is maintained at https://heavymetalcertified.com/standards/dairy-cheese.

named with their public identifiers; the underlying occurrence and toxicology corpus is maintained on the Heavy Metal Index.